

# NOVA AI

## EMPLOYEE HANDBOOK

A comprehensive guide to Nova.ai's culture, policies, benefits and organizational practices for every employee.

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**How to Use This Handbook**

This handbook provides company-wide guidance. Department-specific procedures are documented separately (HR Policy, IT Onboarding Guide, Finance SOP, Information Security Guidelines, Engineering SOP). Where this handbook and a detailed policy document differ, the detailed policy document takes precedence. Direct questions to your Reporting Manager or the HR Helpdesk via the HR Portal.

# Welcome to Nova.ai

Culture, mission, and how this handbook works

## 1.1 Our Mission

Nova.ai builds applied artificial intelligence products that help enterprises make sense of unstructured knowledge — documents, conversations, and data — at scale. Our mission is to make reliable, explainable AI a practical everyday tool for organizations rather than an experimental novelty. Every employee, regardless of function, contributes to this mission either by building products, supporting customers, or enabling the teams that do.

## 1.2 Our Values

- **Clarity over cleverness** — we prefer solutions that are simple to explain and maintain.
- **Ownership** — employees are trusted to make decisions within their remit and are accountable for outcomes, not just effort.
- **Customer-obsessed** — internal convenience never outweighs the experience we deliver to customers.
- **Candour with respect** — direct feedback is expected, but always delivered constructively.

## 1.3 Purpose and Scope of This Handbook

This handbook applies to all full-time, part-time, and probationary employees of Nova.ai across its Gurugram, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, and Pune offices, as well as employees working remotely or in hybrid arrangements. It does not override statutory rights under Indian labour law, nor does it replace signed employment contracts, which take precedence in case of conflict. Interns and contractors are governed by their individual agreements and the sections of this handbook explicitly referenced therein.

## 1.4 Role of Managers

Managers are the first point of accountability for policy compliance within their teams. This includes maintaining accurate attendance and leave records in the HR Portal, communicating policy updates to their reports within 5 working days of publication, and escalating grievances they cannot resolve to HR within 3 working days. Managers are also expected to model the behaviours described in Chapter 9 (Workplace Conduct).

## 1.5 Role of Employees

Employees are expected to read and understand the policies relevant to their role, safeguard confidential company and customer information at all times (see Chapter 8), collaborate respectfully across teams, and consult the relevant department-specific SOP when a situation is not explicitly addressed in this handbook. Ignorance of a published policy is not treated as a valid justification in disciplinary proceedings.

## 1.6 Handbook Governance

This handbook is owned by the People Operations team and reviewed annually, or sooner if required by regulatory change. The current version number and effective date appear on the cover page. Material changes are communicated company-wide via email and the HR Portal at least 15 working days before taking effect, except where changes are mandated by law with immediate effect.

## 1.7 Living the Values Day to Day

Values are assessed as part of the competency framework described in Chapter 6, not treated as posters on a wall. Managers are expected to cite specific value-aligned (or misaligned) behaviours during performance conversations, and peer feedback explicitly references which value a piece of feedback

relates to, to keep the language concrete rather than abstract.

## Company Overview & Structure

Where we operate and how teams are organized

### 2.1 Office Locations

Nova.ai operates from four offices in India. The Gurugram office serves as the corporate headquarters, hosting Executive Leadership, Finance, and Sales. Bengaluru hosts the largest Engineering and AI Research presence. Hyderabad is home to Customer Success and parts of Product. Pune hosts IT Operations and a growing Engineering satellite team.

| Location      | Primary Functions                      | Approx. Headcount |
|---------------|----------------------------------------|-------------------|
| Gurugram (HQ) | Executive Leadership, Finance, Sales   | 30%               |
| Bengaluru     | Engineering, AI Research               | 38%               |
| Hyderabad     | Customer Success, Product              | 20%               |
| Pune          | IT Operations, Engineering (satellite) | 12%               |

### 2.2 Departmental Structure

Core departments include Engineering, AI Research, Product, Sales, Customer Success, Finance, Human Resources, and IT. Engineering and AI Research report jointly into the Chief Technology Officer. Sales and Customer Success report into the Chief Revenue Officer. Finance, HR, and IT report into the Chief Operating Officer, who also chairs the internal Risk & Compliance Committee.

### 2.3 Reporting Lines and Spans of Control

Nova.ai maintains a target span of control of 6–8 direct reports per manager to ensure adequate coaching and performance visibility. Org charts are published and kept current on the internal Knowledge Base; employees can verify their reporting line and escalation path there at any time.

### 2.4 Cross-Functional Collaboration Norms

Given the cross-office structure, meetings involving more than one location default to a documented agenda circulated at least 24 hours in advance, and minutes are posted to the shared workspace within 1 business day. Employees are encouraged to default to asynchronous communication (documented in Slack channels or the Engineering Wiki) before scheduling a synchronous meeting.

### 2.5 External Representation

Employees speaking at public events, publishing technical content, or engaging with media on behalf of Nova.ai must obtain prior sign-off from their department head and the Communications team, in line with the Meeting & Communication Standards document.

# Employment Lifecycle

From recruitment to exit

## 3.1 Recruitment and Onboarding

All open positions are filled through the standardized recruitment process described in the Recruitment & Hiring Guide, which includes structured interviews, panel scoring, and reference checks. New hires complete a structured 2-week onboarding programme coordinated by HR and IT (see the IT Onboarding Guide for equipment and access provisioning timelines).

## 3.2 Probation and Confirmation

New employees serve a probation period of 6 months from their date of joining. Managers must conduct a formal probation review at the 3-month mark and a confirmation review before the 6-month mark, documented in the HR Portal. Probation may be extended by up to 3 months in cases where performance evidence is inconclusive, with written justification from the manager.

## 3.3 Internal Mobility and Transfers

Employees who have completed at least 12 months in their current role are eligible to apply for internal transfers via the internal job board. Transfers require sign-off from both the current and receiving manager, and a maximum 4-week transition/handover period.

## 3.4 Promotions

Promotions are considered twice yearly, aligned with the performance review cycles described in Chapter 6. Promotion decisions are calibrated across department heads to ensure consistency, and are communicated alongside the relevant compensation review.

## 3.5 Resignation and Notice Period

Employees who wish to resign must submit a written resignation through the HR Portal. The standard notice period is 60 days for employees at Manager level and above, and 30 days for all other roles, unless the employment contract specifies otherwise. Buyout of notice period is possible with mutual written agreement between the employee and their department head.

## 3.6 Exit Management

Exiting employees complete a structured exit checklist covering knowledge transfer, asset return (see Asset Management Policy), access revocation, and a confidential exit interview conducted by HR. Full and final settlement, including leave encashment, is processed within 45 days of the last working day.

## **Working Hours & Attendance**

Schedules, flexibility, and time tracking

### **4.1 Standard Working Hours**

Employees work a standard 5-day week, Monday to Friday, totalling 40 hours. Core collaboration hours are 11:00 AM to 4:00 PM IST, during which employees are expected to be reachable regardless of their chosen start time. Outside core hours, employees may exercise flexible start and end times based on personal preference and team agreement.

### **4.2 Attendance Tracking**

Attendance is logged through the HR Portal via daily check-in/check-out or calendar-linked auto-detection for hybrid employees. Discrepancies must be corrected within 3 working days; uncorrected discrepancies beyond this window require manager approval to amend.

### **4.3 Hybrid and Remote Work**

Engineering, AI Research, and Product functions default to a hybrid model of 3 in-office days per week, coordinated at the team level. Fully remote arrangements require Head of Department approval and are reviewed every 6 months. Regardless of arrangement, all employees must be reachable during core collaboration hours and maintain a stable internet connection meeting the minimum bandwidth requirement specified in the IT Onboarding Guide.

### **4.4 Overtime and Compensatory Time**

Overtime is not a routine expectation at Nova.ai. Where extended hours are required to meet a critical deadline, the manager must pre-approve the additional hours, and employees are entitled to compensatory time off within 30 days, as detailed in the Leave Policy.

### **4.5 Late Arrival and Irregular Attendance**

Employees are expected to inform their manager in advance of any anticipated late arrival beyond 30 minutes past their usual start time. Patterns of unexplained irregular attendance (more than 4 instances in a rolling 30-day period) trigger a documented conversation with the manager and, if unresolved, referral to HR.

### **4.6 Travel Time**

Time spent travelling for business purposes between offices or to client sites during working hours is counted as working time. Travel outside standard hours is governed separately by the Travel Policy, including applicable compensatory rest provisions for travel exceeding 4 hours.

## Employee Benefits

Health, wellness, learning, and recognition

### 5.1 Health Insurance

All confirmed employees are covered under a group medical insurance policy providing cover of ■5,00,000 per family floater, extending to spouse, up to two children, and dependent parents. Enrolment of dependents must be completed within 30 days of joining or of a qualifying life event (marriage, childbirth).

### 5.2 Learning and Certification Budget

Each employee is allocated an annual learning budget of ■40,000 for courses, certifications, and conference attendance relevant to their role, reimbursable on submission of receipts and a brief learning summary through the Reimbursement Policy process. Unused budget does not carry forward to the next year.

### 5.3 Wellness Programme

Nova.ai provides access to a confidential Employee Assistance Programme (EAP) offering counselling sessions, a subsidized gym membership reimbursement of up to ■2,000 per month, and an annual wellness leave of 2 additional days that do not draw from standard leave balances.

### 5.4 Referral Bonus

Employees who refer a successful candidate through the internal referral programme receive a bonus of ■50,000 for standard roles and ■1,00,000 for specified hard-to-fill AI Research roles, disbursed in two tranches: 50% on the referred employee's confirmation of joining and 50% on their successful confirmation after probation.

### 5.5 Annual Incentives

Eligible employees participate in an annual incentive programme linked to individual performance ratings (Chapter 6) and company-wide financial performance, paid out in Q1 of the following financial year.

### 5.6 Parental and Family Support

In addition to statutory maternity and paternity leave (see the Leave Policy), Nova.ai provides a creche reimbursement benefit of up to ■8,000 per month for children under 5 years, and a phased return-to-work option allowing reduced hours for up to 8 weeks following parental leave.



## Performance Management

Goals, reviews, and career growth

### 6.1 Goal Setting

Employees set quarterly goals in collaboration with their manager, aligned to team and company objectives, using the OKR (Objectives and Key Results) framework. Goals are logged in the Performance Portal within the first 2 weeks of each quarter.

### 6.2 Review Cycle

Formal performance reviews occur twice yearly (April and October), supplemented by lightweight monthly check-ins between employee and manager. Reviews incorporate self-assessment, manager assessment, and 360-degree peer feedback for roles above the individual-contributor level.

### 6.3 Competency Framework

Performance is assessed against a competency framework spanning four dimensions: technical excellence, ownership and delivery, collaboration, and growth mindset. Each dimension is rated on a 4-point scale, and ratings are calibrated across managers within a department to ensure consistency before being finalized.

| Rating             | Descriptor                           | Typical Outcome                        |
|--------------------|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| Exceptional        | Consistently exceeds expectations    | Eligible for accelerated promotion     |
| Strong             | Meets and often exceeds expectations | Standard increment, promotion-eligible |
| Meets Expectations | Solid, consistent performance        | Standard increment                     |
| Needs Improvement  | Falls short in one or more areas     | Performance Improvement Plan (PIP)     |

### 6.4 Performance Improvement Plans (PIP)

Employees rated "Needs Improvement" are placed on a structured 60-day Performance Improvement Plan with clearly defined, measurable objectives, fortnightly check-ins, and documented HR involvement. Failure to meet PIP objectives may result in separation, subject to due process.

### 6.5 Promotion Readiness

Promotion readiness is assessed based on sustained performance at the target level for at least 2 consecutive review cycles, manager and skip-level endorsement, and calibration committee approval. Employees can nominate themselves for consideration via the Performance Portal.

### 6.6 Career Growth Conversations

Beyond formal reviews, employees are entitled to a dedicated career growth conversation with their manager at least once per quarter, separate from performance discussions, focused on long-term development and internal mobility interests.

## **Learning & Development**

Building skills and internal expertise

### **7.1 Nova Academy**

Nova Academy is the internal learning platform offering self-paced technical courses, live instructor-led workshops, and role-specific onboarding tracks. All employees receive access on their first day, and completion of assigned compliance modules (data privacy, information security awareness) is mandatory within the first 30 days.

### **7.2 Mentoring Programme**

New employees are paired with a peer mentor for their first 90 days to support onboarding and informal knowledge transfer. Employees may additionally opt into the cross-functional mentoring programme, matched twice yearly based on stated development goals.

### **7.3 Technical Workshops and Hackathons**

Engineering and AI Research host monthly technical workshops open to all employees, and a company-wide hackathon twice a year. Winning teams receive recognition at the town hall and priority consideration for incubating their idea as an internal project.

### **7.4 Leadership Development**

Employees identified in the talent review process, or who self-nominate with manager endorsement, may join the Nova Leadership Track, a 6-month programme covering people management, stakeholder communication, and strategic decision-making, delivered in partnership with an external training provider.

### **7.5 External Certifications**

External certifications relevant to an employee's role (cloud platforms, security certifications, AI/ML specializations) are reimbursable under the learning budget described in Section 5.2, provided the certification is pre-approved by the manager and the employee remains with the Company for at least 6 months post-certification, or reimburses a pro-rated amount.

### **7.6 Conference Attendance**

Employees may request sponsorship to attend industry conferences relevant to their function. Requests are prioritized for employees presenting or representing Nova.ai, subject to budget availability and Head of Department approval at least 4 weeks in advance.

## Information Security

Protecting company and customer data

### 8.1 Access Control and Least Privilege

Access to systems and data is granted strictly on a least-privilege, role-based basis. Access requests beyond an employee's default role require manager approval and are automatically reviewed every 90 days by IT Security. Full detail is provided in the Information Security Guidelines and Data Classification Policy.

### 8.2 Authentication Requirements

Multi-factor authentication (MFA) is mandatory for all corporate systems, including email, VPN, and internal tools. Passwords must be a minimum of 14 characters, changed every 180 days, and must not be reused across the last 10 password cycles.

### 8.3 Remote Access and VPN

All access to internal systems from outside the office network must be routed through the corporate VPN. Use of unsecured public Wi-Fi without VPN for company work is strictly prohibited.

### 8.4 Data Classification and Handling

All company data is classified as Public, Internal, Confidential, or Restricted, per the Data Classification Policy. Confidential and Restricted data must be encrypted at rest and in transit, and must never be transferred to personal devices or personal cloud storage accounts.

#### Quick Reference: Data Classification

**Public** — marketing material, public blog posts. **Internal** — org charts, internal wikis. **Confidential** — customer contracts, financial reports. **Restricted** — customer PII, security credentials, model weights.

### 8.5 Incident Reporting

Any suspected security incident — phishing attempt, lost device, unauthorized access, suspected data leak — must be reported immediately to security@nova.ai or via the IT Helpdesk, and no later than 2 hours after discovery. Delayed reporting of a known incident is itself treated as a policy violation.

### 8.6 Acceptable Use of AI Tools

Employees using third-party generative AI tools for work purposes must not input Confidential or Restricted data (Section 8.4) into any tool not explicitly approved by IT Security. A list of approved AI tools is maintained on the Engineering Wiki and reviewed quarterly.

# **Workplace Conduct**

Professional behaviour, respect, and ethics

## **9.1 Professional Behaviour**

Employees are expected to conduct themselves with professionalism and courtesy in all interactions, whether in person, in writing, or in virtual meetings, and regardless of seniority or reporting relationship.

## **9.2 Anti-Harassment and Anti-Discrimination**

Nova.ai maintains zero tolerance for harassment, discrimination, or retaliation based on gender, religion, caste, disability, sexual orientation, or any other protected characteristic under applicable law. Complaints are handled under the Internal Committee (IC) constituted in accordance with the POSH Act, 2013, with strict confidentiality and a target resolution timeline of 90 days.

## **9.3 Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion**

Nova.ai is committed to building a workforce reflective of the communities it serves. Hiring panels are required to include at least one member from a different function or gender than the hiring manager, and DEI metrics are reviewed quarterly by the Executive Leadership Team.

## **9.4 Confidentiality Obligations**

Employees must not disclose confidential company or customer information to any external party without authorization, both during employment and after separation, in line with the confidentiality clause of their employment contract and the Data Classification Policy.

## **9.5 Conflicts of Interest**

Employees must disclose any actual or potential conflict of interest — including outside employment, financial interest in a vendor or competitor, or close personal relationships with direct reports — to HR promptly upon becoming aware of it.

## **9.6 Disciplinary Process**

Policy violations are addressed through a graded disciplinary process — verbal warning, written warning, final written warning, and separation — proportionate to the severity and recurrence of the violation. Gross misconduct (fraud, harassment, data theft) may result in immediate termination without proceeding through the graded steps.

## Employee Resources

Portals, tools, and where to get help

### 10.1 HR Portal

The HR Portal is the single point of access for leave applications, attendance records, payslips, tax declarations, and policy documents. Employees should raise any HR query through the Portal's ticketing system for a documented, trackable response.

### 10.2 Learning Management System (Nova Academy)

As described in Chapter 7, Nova Academy hosts all mandatory compliance training, role-based learning tracks, and optional skill-building courses.

### 10.3 Engineering Wiki and Knowledge Base

The Engineering Wiki documents system architecture, API references, and engineering standard operating procedures. The company-wide Knowledge Base hosts org charts, meeting norms, and cross-departmental FAQs.

### 10.4 IT Helpdesk

The IT Helpdesk handles hardware issues, software access requests, and security incident reporting, with a standard response SLA of 4 business hours for non-urgent tickets and 30 minutes for tickets marked critical.

### 10.5 Expense and Reimbursement Portal

Travel, learning, wellness, and other eligible reimbursements are claimed through the Expense Portal, in line with the Reimbursement Policy. Claims must be submitted within 30 days of the expense being incurred, accompanied by valid receipts.

### 10.6 Getting Help: Escalation Matrix

| Concern Type        | First Point of Contact  | Escalation         |
|---------------------|-------------------------|--------------------|
| Leave / Attendance  | HR Portal ticket        | Reporting Manager  |
| Harassment / POSH   | Internal Committee (IC) | Head of HR         |
| IT / Access issues  | IT Helpdesk             | IT Operations Lead |
| Security incident   | security@nova.ai        | CISO               |
| Payroll discrepancy | HR Portal ticket        | Finance Controller |

## Appendix: Policy Cross-Reference Index

Where to find detailed guidance beyond this handbook

This handbook intentionally provides company-wide, high-level guidance. Detailed operating procedures live in standalone policy documents, owned by the relevant department and available on the HR Portal and Knowledge Base. The table below maps each related document to the handbook chapter it supports.

| Related Document                          | Owning Function         | Relevant Chapter(s) |
|-------------------------------------------|-------------------------|---------------------|
| Employee Handbook                         | People Operations       | All chapters        |
| HR Policy                                 | Human Resources         | Ch. 3, 5, 9         |
| Leave Policy                              | Human Resources         | Ch. 3, 4            |
| Code of Conduct                           | Human Resources / Legal | Ch. 9               |
| Performance Management Policy             | People Operations       | Ch. 6               |
| Recruitment & Hiring Guide                | Talent Acquisition      | Ch. 3               |
| Travel Policy                             | Finance                 | Ch. 4, 5            |
| Reimbursement Policy                      | Finance                 | Ch. 5, 7            |
| Finance Standard Operating Procedures     | Finance                 | Ch. 2               |
| IT Onboarding Guide                       | IT Operations           | Ch. 3, 4            |
| Information Security Guidelines           | IT Security             | Ch. 8               |
| Data Classification Policy                | IT Security             | Ch. 8               |
| Engineering Standard Operating Procedures | Engineering             | Ch. 2, 10           |
| API Documentation                         | Engineering             | Ch. 10              |
| System Architecture Guide                 | Engineering             | Ch. 10              |
| AI Product Documentation                  | AI Research / Product   | Ch. 2               |
| Customer Support Manual                   | Customer Success        | Ch. 2               |
| Customer FAQs                             | Customer Success        | Ch. 10              |
| Sales Playbook                            | Sales                   | Ch. 2               |
| Asset Management Policy                   | IT Operations           | Ch. 3               |
| Meeting & Communication Standards         | People Operations       | Ch. 2               |

In the event of any conflict between this handbook and a document listed above, the department-owned document governs for matters within its specific scope, while this handbook governs for general company-wide expectations. Employees unsure which document applies should raise a query through the HR Portal.

## Revision History

| Version | Effective Date  | Summary of Changes                                               |
|---------|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1.0     | 01 April 2023   | Initial company-wide handbook published.                         |
| 2.0     | 01 April 2024   | Added hybrid work guidance (Ch. 4); expanded benefits (Ch. 5).   |
| 2.5     | 01 October 2025 | Updated Information Security chapter for AI tool usage (Ch. 8).  |
| 3.0     | 01 April 2026   | Full restructure; added Policy Cross-Reference Index (Appendix). |

## Glossary of Terms

| Term | Definition                                                                               |
|------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| EAP  | Employee Assistance Programme &mdash; confidential counselling and wellness support.     |
| IC   | Internal Committee constituted under the POSH Act, 2013 to handle harassment complaints. |
| LWP  | Leave Without Pay &mdash; unpaid leave granted once other leave balances are exhausted.  |
| MFA  | Multi-Factor Authentication &mdash; a login requiring more than one verification method. |
| OKR  | Objectives and Key Results &mdash; the goal-setting framework used across Nova.ai.       |
| PIP  | Performance Improvement Plan &mdash; a structured plan for underperforming employees.    |
| SOP  | Standard Operating Procedure &mdash; a department-owned, detailed process document.      |

## Frequently Asked Questions

### Q: Can I carry forward unused Earned Leave to next year?

A: Yes, up to a maximum of 45 accumulated days. Beyond this cap, any additional balance lapses at the end of the leave year unless encashed under the Leave Policy.

### Q: Who approves a request to work fully remote?

A: Fully remote arrangements require Head of Department approval and are reviewed every 6 months, as described in Section 4.3.

### Q: What happens if I miss the exit checklist steps?

A: Full and final settlement may be delayed beyond the standard 45-day window until all exit checklist items, including asset return, are completed.

### Q: Can I use ChatGPT or similar tools for work tasks?

A: Only tools listed on the approved AI tools list (Engineering Wiki) may be used, and Confidential or Restricted data must never be entered into any unapproved tool, per Section 8.6.

### Q: How do I report a harassment concern confidentially?

A: Complaints are directed to the Internal Committee (IC) constituted under the POSH Act, 2013, and are handled with strict confidentiality, targeting resolution within 90 days.

### Q: Is overtime compensated in cash?

A: No. Pre-approved overtime is compensated through compensatory time off within 30 days rather than cash payment, as described in Section 4.4.

### Q: How often are performance ratings calibrated?

A: Ratings are calibrated across managers within a department before being finalized, at each of the two formal review cycles per year (April and October), as described in Section 6.3.

**Q: What is the notice period if I resign as an individual contributor?**

A: The standard notice period is 30 days for roles below Manager level, unless the employment contract specifies a different term, as described in Section 3.5.

**Document Control**

This handbook (NV-HB-001, v3.0) is a synthetically generated sample document created for demonstration and RAG-project portfolio purposes. It does not represent an actual company or actual policy terms.